

Technical Report Writing (TRW)

Chapter No 10
(Techniques)

Describing

Chapter in a Nutshell

- What is a description?
- Mechanism, process and human system
- How to plan a description?
- How to write a description

What is a description?

Descriptions orient readers to objects, machines, parts, mechanisms, processes or human systems. Sometimes we describe in detail and sometimes in broad outlines. The purpose is to make the readers feel in control of the topic or subject.

Mechanism: is a way of doing something, which is planned or is part of a system.

Process: is a series of actions that we take in order to achieve a result.

Human system: is a sequence of actions in which one or more people act in specified ways.

A writer like you may have to describe a part, a machine, a process, a mechanism or a human system.

How to plan a description?

Consider the audience: Consider their knowledge level and that why they need this description.

Select an organizational principal: This means choose from a number of options in order to organize and write the description methodically.

Left to right or right to left

Top to bottom or bottom to top

Outside to inside or inside to outside

Most important to least important or least to most important

Not: Base this decision on the need of your audience.

Choose suitable visual aids: Suitable visual aids can be used to reinforce the written description for better understanding of the audience.

Follow the usual form for a description: Generally, descriptions do not stand alone but are part of a larger document or report. However, these have an introduction section, which should briefly define the (process, mechanism, human system or part) the goal of the writer that what is intended, the goal for the reader that what should they find and understand. This will clearly bring forth the purpose of the description (be it a mechanism, process or part description or description of a human system) and lets the audience preview what is to come. Then there is a body section, which includes the details heading by heading . Conclusions are optional.

How to describe the parts is a machine?

Function method: By naming the part and by briefly describing its function, the part gets automatically described.

Generalized method: Instead of part by part description, convey various facts about the machine, like its general detail, physical description and detail of functions.

General detail means: providing definition and operational principle.

Physical description means: providing information on shape, size, weight, appearance, hardness and method of assembly.

Detail of functions means: providing information on how it works, its applications, efficiency, special constraints, how it is controlled and how long it performs before it needs service.

NOTE: If for example in an organization a requirement arises where description is needed to be written for an audience(can be an officer, a senior, a subordinate, a committee and so on). It means this will be an in-house or intra-organizational document and hence falls into the category of an informal report. Hence, the description will be written in the light of chapter 10 and in the format of memorandum chapter 12.

Similarly, if it is a short research based report or in-house/intra-organizational report, it will also be written in the format of memorandum and in IMRD(Introduction, Methodology, Result, Discussion) form. In the same manner, brief analytical and progress reports will also be written in their formats in memorandums.

Thank you!